A Guide to Disaster Relief Funding Opportunities

How to Navigate the Funding Process

U.S. Senator Kirsten Gillibrand

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Introduction

Dear Fellow New Yorker,

Recovering from a disaster is usually a gradual process. Safety is the first priority, along with your mental and physical well-being. Help is available, and knowing how to reach it makes recovery faster and less stressful. As your Senator, your and your family's safety and well-being are top of mind, which is why I have put together this guide to disaster response and recovery resources for New Yorkers.

This guide lists federal, New York State, and other resources for individuals and families, businesses and nonprofits, farmers, and communities. It is a starting point, not a complete list, and programs change, so please confirm details with the agency before you apply. Each entry includes a link to the official program page.

If you need help with a federal agency, my office may be able to assist. Visit gillibrand.senate.gov or call my Washington, D.C. office at (202) 224-4451. As you move forward with any grant opportunities, please contact Anita Sagar on my staff at grants@gillibrand.senate.gov about letters of support, when applicable.

Sincerely,

Kirsten Gillibrand

United States Senator

Response and Recovery: Understanding the Next Steps of a Disaster

When a disaster is declared, the federal government, led by the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), responds at the request of, and in support of, states, Tribes, territories, and local governments. Some federal help, such as FEMA assistance for individuals, is only available after the President declares a major disaster for your county. Other help, such as crop insurance, flood insurance, and some USDA programs, does not require a declaration.

Recovery often begins while emergency response is still under way. In New York, the State Division of Homeland Security and Emergency Services (DHSES) coordinates with FEMA and runs four recovery program areas: Public Assistance, Individual Assistance, Hazard Mitigation, and Disaster Finance.

Key Numbers to Keep Handy

- **Apply for FEMA assistance:** DisasterAssistance.gov or the FEMA Helpline, 1-800-621-3362 (7 a.m. to 10 p.m., 7 days a week)
- **Local help in New York:** call 211 (outside New York City) or 311 (in New York City)
- **SBA disaster loans:** 1-800-659-2955 or disastercustomerservice@sba.gov; TTY users dial 7-1-1
- **Free emergency alerts:** NY-Alert
- **Flood insurance claims (NFIP):** 1-877-336-2627
- **Emotional distress after a disaster:** call or text the Disaster Distress Helpline, 1-800-985-5990, or call or text 988

Help for Individuals and Families

FEMA Individual Assistance (DisasterAssistance.gov)

After a presidentially declared disaster that includes Individual Assistance, FEMA can help eligible people with needs not covered by insurance, such as temporary housing and home repairs. DisasterAssistance.gov is the federal government's single place to apply for FEMA assistance, check the status of an application, upload documents, and find other recovery help.

Besides housing help, FEMA's Individuals and Households Program can cover other serious disaster-related needs not met by insurance, such as medical and dental costs, child care, funeral costs, personal property, and transportation. You must apply first; FEMA may refer you to SBA for a low-interest loan before some of this help is available.

- Check whether your county is included in a declaration and apply online at DisasterAssistance.gov.
- Each disaster has an application deadline; disasters with past dates may still accept late applications.
- If you need help completing your application, call the FEMA Helpline at 1-800-621-3362, 7 a.m. to 10 p.m. (your time zone), 7 days a week. If you use a video relay service or captioned telephone, give FEMA the number for that service.

SBA Home and Personal Property Disaster Loans

The U.S. Small Business Administration (SBA) offers low-interest, long-term disaster loans to homeowners and renters in declared disaster areas. You do not need to own a business.

- **Home loans:** homeowners may borrow up to $500,000 to repair or replace their primary residence.
- **Personal property loans:** homeowners and renters may borrow up to $100,000 to repair or replace personal property such as clothing, furniture, cars, and appliances.
- Insurance and other recovery payments may be deducted from the eligible loan amount. Second homes and vacation properties are not eligible.
- Loans may be increased to pay for improvements that reduce future damage, such as retaining walls, sump pumps, and safe rooms.

For more information, visit SBA Disaster Assistance.

Contact: 1-800-659-2955 or disastercustomerservice@sba.gov. TTY users dial 7-1-1.

203(h) Mortgage Insurance for Disaster Victims and 203(k) Rehabilitation Mortgage Insurance

Section 203(h) Mortgage Insurance for Disaster Victims helps people whose homes were destroyed or severely damaged in a presidentially declared disaster area get a mortgage to rebuild or buy another home. No down payment is required, and the borrower may finance 100 percent of the home. You must apply through an FHA-approved lender within one year of the disaster declaration.

Section 203(k) Rehabilitation Mortgage Insurance lets you buy or refinance a home that is at least a year old and finance the cost of repairing it in a single mortgage. For repairs that do not require buying or refinancing, HUD's Title I Property Improvement Loan Program may be an option.

For more information, visit Section 203(h) and Section 203(k).

Contact: 1-800-CALL-FHA (1-800-225-5342), TTY 1-800-877-8339, Answers@hud.gov

Disaster Unemployment Assistance

Disaster Unemployment Assistance provides weekly benefits and re-employment services to people whose job or self-employment was lost or interrupted as a direct result of a presidentially declared major disaster that includes Individual Assistance, and who are not eligible for regular

unemployment insurance. You will need proof of employment or self-employment. Apply through the New York State Department of Labor after a declaration.

For more information, visit the U.S. Department of Labor's Disaster Recovery Assistance page, or call 1-866-487-2365.

Disaster Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (D-SNAP) and Disaster Food Help

After a disaster, USDA works with the State to provide food assistance:

- **D-SNAP:** if stores are open in the affected area, the State may run a Disaster Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program. D-SNAP uses different rules than regular SNAP, so households that would not normally qualify may be eligible because of disaster-related expenses such as home repairs, temporary shelter, evacuation, or lost income. Benefits are loaded on an EBT card.
- **Current SNAP households** may be able to get replacement benefits for food lost in the disaster, and in some declared disasters may be allowed to buy hot, prepared foods for a period of time.
- **USDA Foods Disaster Household Distribution:** when normal food channels are disrupted, the State may distribute boxes of USDA Foods, usually for two weeks to one month. Families may receive both D-SNAP and a USDA Foods box.

For more information, visit USDA Disaster Assistance.

Contact: New York State SNAP Hotline, 1-800-342-3009

Home Energy Assistance (HEAP / LIHEAP)

The federal Low Income Home Energy Assistance Program (LIHEAP) helps low-income households with home heating and cooling bills, energy crises, and weatherization and minor energy-related repairs. In New York, it is run by the Office of Temporary and Disability Assistance as the Home Energy Assistance Program (HEAP), which includes emergency benefits for households facing a heating emergency.

For more information, visit NYS HEAP or contact your local Department of Social Services.

Insurance Help: Flood Insurance and New York State Insurance Assistance

Most homeowners and renters insurance does not cover flood damage. Flood insurance is available separately through FEMA's National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) for homeowners, renters, and businesses in participating communities. Coverage limits are up to $250,000 for a home and $100,000 for its contents, and up to $500,000 each for non-residential buildings and their contents.

- Report a flood loss right away to your insurance agent or company. Need help finding them? Call the NFIP at 1-877-336-2627 or visit FloodSmart.gov.
- The New York State Department of Financial Services (DFS) can answer questions about coverage and claims and accepts complaints about insurers. Visit DFS Disaster and Flood Recovery or call the DFS Disaster Hotline at 1-800-339-1759.
- Before a disaster, keep photos or video of your home and belongings and a copy of your policy in a safe, dry place.

Disaster Legal Services

Disaster Legal Services (DLS) provides free legal advice to low-income survivors of a presidentially declared major disaster that includes Individual Assistance. FEMA provides this service through an agreement with the Young Lawyers Division of the American Bar Association, and help is limited to cases that will not generate a fee. DLS can help with insurance claims, landlord and tenant problems, home repair contracts, consumer protection matters, mortgage foreclosure problems, and replacing wills and other important legal documents lost in the disaster.

Contact: FEMA Helpline, 1-800-621-3362

Federal Benefit Payments: Switch from Paper Checks

Since September 30, 2025, the federal government has stopped issuing paper checks for most federal payments, including Social Security and veterans benefits, except in very limited circumstances. Electronic payments are safer during a disaster because they do not depend on mail delivery.

- **Direct deposit:** sign up through the agency that pays your benefits, at GoDirect.gov, or by calling the Electronic Payment Solution Center at 1-800-967-6857 (Monday to Friday, 9 a.m. to 7 p.m. ET).
- **Direct Express® Debit Mastercard®:** a prepaid card for people without a bank account. Cards are now issued by Fifth Third Bank. Visit USDirectExpress.com.

Mental Health Support After a Disaster

- **Disaster Distress Helpline:** call or text 1-800-985-5990 to talk with a trained counselor, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call, text, or chat 988, 24/7. Free and confidential.
- **SAMHSA National Helpline:** 1-800-662-HELP (4357), free, confidential treatment referral, in English and Spanish.
- **Find treatment:** FindTreatment.gov

For more information, visit SAMHSA: Find Help.

Disaster Resources for Older Adults and People with Disabilities

The Administration for Community Living (ACL) offers resources to help older adults, people with disabilities, families, caregivers, and service providers prepare for and respond to emergencies.

For more information, visit ACL Emergency Preparedness.

Bureau of Indian Affairs Financial Assistance and Social Services (FASS)

The Bureau of Indian Affairs offers financial assistance to American Indians and Alaska Natives who do not have access to TANF, do not qualify for TANF, or have used up their TANF lifetime limit. Help is secondary to other resources. Types of assistance include General Assistance, Child Assistance, Non-Medical Institutional or Custodial Care of Adults, Burial Assistance (up to $3,500), and **Emergency Assistance** (up to $1,500) for people whose homes were damaged or destroyed by fire, flood, or other disasters, to cover food, shelter, and utilities.

For more information, visit BIA Financial Assistance.

Contact: (202) 513-7642 or (202) 513-7622

Help for Businesses and Nonprofits

SBA Disaster Loans for Businesses and Nonprofits

The SBA's Office of Disaster Recovery provides low-interest disaster loans to businesses of all sizes and private nonprofit organizations in declared disaster areas.

- **Business Physical Disaster Loans:** up to $2 million to repair or replace damaged real estate, machinery and equipment, inventory, and other business assets.
- **Economic Injury Disaster Loans (EIDL):** working capital for small businesses, small agricultural cooperatives, small aquaculture businesses, and most private nonprofits that suffered economic injury, even without property damage. The $2 million limit is shared with physical disaster loans.
- **Mitigation:** borrowers may increase an approved physical damage loan to pay for improvements that reduce the risk of future damage.
- **Military Reservist Economic Injury Loans:** help small businesses meet operating expenses when an essential employee is called to active duty.

For more information, visit SBA Disaster Assistance.

Contact: 1-800-659-2955 or disastercustomerservice@sba.gov. TTY users dial 7-1-1.

USDA Business and Industry Loan Guarantees

The Business & Industry (B&I) Guaranteed Loan Program guarantees loans made by private lenders to businesses in rural areas, so lenders can extend more credit. Eligible areas are generally outside cities and towns with more than 50,000 people. Lenders may request a guarantee for loans to for-profit businesses, nonprofits and cooperatives, federally recognized Tribes, public bodies, and individuals.

For more information, visit USDA B&I Loan Guarantees.

Contact: (202) 720-2600

Help for Farmers and Agricultural Producers

USDA Disaster Assistance for Farmers

USDA's Farm Service Agency, Natural Resources Conservation Service, and Risk Management Agency offer programs to help producers prepare for and recover from natural disasters. Crop insurance is purchased through a private crop insurance agent; for other programs, contact your local USDA Service Center.

Visit farmers.gov Protection and Recovery to find programs that fit your situation, and sign up for USDA disaster email updates.

Crop Insurance

Federal crop insurance protects agricultural producers against crop and revenue losses from natural causes. It is administered by USDA's Risk Management Agency (RMA) and sold only through private crop insurance agents. To be covered, you must buy a policy for your crop by the sales closing date in your county.

Find an agent with the RMA Agent Locator or learn more at RMA New York.

Contact: RMA Raleigh Regional Office (serves New York), (919) 875-4880, rsonc@usda.gov

Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance Program (NAP)

USDA's Farm Service Agency (FSA) Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance Program (NAP) pays producers of crops not covered by federal crop insurance when natural disasters cause low yields, loss of inventory, or prevented planting. Eligible crops include commercial crops grown for food, fiber, or bioenergy, as well as nursery and flower crops, Christmas trees, turfgrass sod, seed crops, and aquaculture. You must buy NAP coverage for the crop year before the loss occurs. Owners, landlords, tenants, and sharecroppers who share in the risk of producing the crop may qualify, subject to federal income limits.

For more information, visit farmers.gov or contact your local USDA Service Center.

Contact: FSA New York State Office, (315) 477-6300

Emergency Farm Loans

FSA's Emergency Loan Program helps established family farmers and ranchers recover from losses in counties declared a disaster area by the President or designated by the Secretary of Agriculture (or under a USDA quarantine). Farms in neighboring counties also qualify. Funds may be used to restore or replace essential property, pay production costs for the disaster year, pay essential family living expenses, reorganize the farming operation, and refinance certain debts. Loans are available up to $500,000.

For more information, contact your local USDA Service Center or visit farmers.gov.

Emergency Conservation Program (ECP)

The Emergency Conservation Program shares the cost of emergency work to repair farmland damaged by floods, hurricanes, tornadoes, wildfires, and other natural disasters, to stop disaster-related soil erosion, and to conserve water during severe drought. Owners, landlords, tenants, and sharecroppers who pay part of the cost of an approved practice in a disaster area may apply. Recent awards have ranged from $1,000 to $500,000. Funding depends on availability.

For more information, contact your local USDA Service Center or visit farmers.gov.

Help for Communities, Local Governments, and Tribes

These programs fund recovery and rebuilding by counties, cities, towns, villages, Tribes, and certain nonprofits. In New York, most FEMA community programs are applied for through the State Division of Homeland Security and Emergency Services.

FEMA Public Assistance and Hazard Mitigation (through NYS DHSES)

- **Public Assistance** helps state, local, and Tribal governments and eligible private nonprofits pay for debris removal, emergency protective measures, and repairing or replacing damaged public facilities and infrastructure after a presidentially declared disaster or emergency.
- **Hazard Mitigation Grant Program** funding becomes available after a major disaster declaration for projects that reduce future risk, such as elevating or retrofitting buildings, buying out flood-prone properties, and other resilience projects. A FEMA-approved hazard mitigation plan is required.
- **Flood Mitigation Assistance** funds projects that reduce or eliminate repeated flood damage to buildings insured by the National Flood Insurance Program, such as elevating homes or buying out repeatedly flooded properties. In New York, DHSES applies on behalf of local governments.

For more information, visit NYS DHSES Disaster Recovery.

HUD Community Development Block Grant – Disaster Recovery (CDBG-DR)

When Congress appropriates special funding after major disasters, HUD awards Community Development Block Grant – Disaster Recovery (CDBG-DR) grants to states and local governments to help rebuild housing, infrastructure, and local economies, especially in low- and moderate-income areas. Residents usually apply through the State or local program that receives the grant.

For more information, visit HUD CDBG-DR.

Dislocated Worker Grants for Disaster Cleanup

States affected by disasters can apply to the U.S. Department of Labor for Dislocated Worker Grants, which can create temporary jobs to help with cleanup and recovery.

For more information, visit DOL Disaster Recovery Assistance.

New York State and Local Resources

New York State Office of Emergency Management

The New York State Office of Emergency Management (OEM), part of the Division of Homeland Security and Emergency Services (DHSES), coordinates the activities of all State agencies to protect New York's communities from natural and human-caused disasters. It supports local governments, voluntary organizations, and private industry with planning, response, technical support, and disaster recovery assistance.

- To learn about available resources after a disaster, call 211 (outside New York City) or 311 (in New York City).
- Sign up for free emergency alerts by phone, email, or text at NY-Alert.

For more information, visit NYS Office of Emergency Management.

Contact: DHSESPIO@dhses.ny.gov, (518) 242-5000

New York State Homes and Community Renewal Disaster Repair Programs

After some major storms, New York State Homes and Community Renewal (HCR) has opened emergency repair programs, through local nonprofit partners, that help homeowners make primary residences safe and livable when insurance and other aid fall short. Past programs offered grants of up to $50,000 based on income. These programs are announced after specific disasters.

Check Resilient NY Recovery Resources for current State recovery programs.

Private and Philanthropic Disaster Funding

- **American Red Cross:** emergency shelter, food, and other immediate help. Find an open shelter through DisasterAssistance.gov or call 1-800-RED-CROSS (1-800-733-2767).
- **Center for Disaster Philanthropy:** information on how foundations and donors fund long-term disaster recovery, at DisasterPhilanthropy.org.
- Local community foundations and United Way chapters often open disaster funds after a major event; call 211 to find them.

Letters of Support from Senator Gillibrand

While Senator Gillibrand does NOT decide which organizations are awarded grants, there are instances in which it is appropriate for Senator Gillibrand to write a letter of support for an application. If you wish to request a letter of support, please send the following to grants@gillibrand.senate.gov:

- A description of your organization
- A summary of the application
- A description of what the money will be used for
- A draft letter of support

Senator Gillibrand's Offices

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Washington, DC 20510
Tel. (202) 224-4451

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885 Third Avenue, Suite 2402
New York, NY 10022

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Leo W. O'Brien Federal Office Building
11A Clinton Avenue, Room 821
Albany, NY 12207

Buffalo
Larkin at Exchange
726 Exchange Street, Suite 511
Buffalo, NY 14210

Long Island
155 Pinelawn Road, Suite 250 North
Melville, NY 11747

Lower Hudson Valley
P.O. Box 749
Yonkers, NY 10710

Rochester
Kenneth B. Keating Federal Office Building
100 State Street, Room 4195
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